Lifetime of Loving You

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Mature

Archive Warnings:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

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F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Medieval, Sort Of, no magic, No Smut, Knight Adora, Rogue Catra, Archer Bow, Fantasy, also sort of, Freeform, talks of blood, but not too much, Past Child Abuse, Emotional Manipulation, courtesy of, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Character Death, Violence, Swords, Adora has a sword, Catra has blades, Glimmer has a spear, Bow has a bow, Rated For Violence

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by wack_lumpia

Summary

It scares Adora just how much she’s willing to do anything for this girl. Growing up they didn’t really have much and other kids come and go but what’s constant with her life was always Catra. All those years that they pushed through life together, beating any odds that came their way. It scares her just how much she wants to give up everything she knows just for this girl but she can’t do that. She can’t let herself succumb to what she wants, not when she’s needed elsewhere and not when she has to be the person she needs to be. She wants to though. She wants Catra, she wants her to be safe and happy, always.

or

Adora and the Alliance prepare to face what they've been fighting for, for so long. The war wages on, Salineas has been captured by King Prime and all of Etheria is tired of his imperialistic ideology.

or

Adora is a knight and Catra is a Rogue. My own take on a medieval au

Notes

Hello! First off, this is a one-shot that focuses more on Adora's relationship with Catra. I know Knight Adora isn't new and there's a lot of good knight au out there. This is inspired by me listening to Soldier, Poet, King by The Oh Hellos on repeat, and also me repeating the word "Lifetime" over and over in my head. Before you read this I'd like to warn you again of the depictions of violence, talks about blood and past

child abuse: physical and psychological manipulation. I hope you enjoy this, I planned and wrote this for weeks now and I'm excited to share it with you guys. Enjoy!

Ps: Only the first few parts were proofread lol

See the end of the work for more notes

The ship creaks as it sails through the riptides of the ocean. They are nearing their destination with a fleet of ships following close behind them. Everyone aboard has solemn and focused faces. There is an unspoken pressure lingering around them, it's tense, mixed with the cool breeze of the night's air. No chatter nor whispers can be heard, only the sea singing as they sail through.

Adora grips the hilt of her sword, feeling all that pressure on the air, looking out towards their destination. Her eyes squint in anticipation. They'd disembark off the ship soon enough, executing the mission at hand. She and the rest of the alliance had planned this for what little preparation they had. They felt the rage and adrenaline coursing through them once they heard of the news. They wasted no time in strategizing a battle plan to not only rescue the remaining Salineans, retrieve the land back to Mermista's name but also plan to end the war entirely. The war that has been going on for as long as Adora could remember. Too many casualties and too many lives destroyed because of the war. The more it drags on the more lives are lost. This is their one opportunity to end it all for good; a risk they were all willing to take when they argued inside the war room.

As she stands at the forefront of the boat, sea air swaying her short blonde hair, the moon shining on her gold-rimmed armor, she can't help but think of all the times she had to fight and all the times she wished she didn't have to. She wonders about everything that had happened to her life and ponders if it was all just leading her to this moment or maybe it was all her choices. If she would have done things differently would it all have been easier than this? She spent this entire lifetime fighting. She wonders if it was enough.

She sighs, closing her eyes, not wanting her head to spiral right now. She runs her fingers through her hair, feeling it dance with the wind blowing. Knowing their enemy (or what little they know), nothing would be easy with him.

Prime. She grits her teeth just at the thought of him. The bane to her existence. If it weren't for him, there wouldn't be a war, if it weren't for him there wouldn't be any meaningless death or unnecessary suffering just because of power and greed. If it weren't for him maybe she would have been beside *her* right now and Adora wouldn't have fought all through her life. She had been prepped at a young age to be the soldier leading a battalion for him. She was pushed to be the best and only the best, manipulated - for what? Money? Power? It was all the same to her honestly and she's done with all of it. Soon this war will end and maybe everything that had happened before will just be another distant memory she'll forget, but that's not what she wants. Despite all the things she remembers, those memories were also tied to *her* and she wants to remember her even if it is painful to remember.

Maybe it would be different at another time.

She sighs once again, opening her eyes and staring back at the destination ahead of her, noting the missing stars up in the sky. This will all be over soon, she thinks tightening her hold on the hilt of her sword. The night is dark and the path is hidden.

"Hey," she hears the floorboard creak as footsteps near her. There's a hand on top of her shoulder plate. She turns her head slightly to face the newcomer. A reassuring smile looks back at her. "Captain Sea Hawk says we'll arrive in an hour."

She nods and turns back towards where her gaze was before. An hour left. Her chest tightens at the thought. An hour left before they dance with death.

Suddenly she feels another weight on her shoulder, she turns to the opposite side of where the hand still resides and her vision covers with a sight full of pink hair, as a head, rests on her shoulders and arms wrapping around her own.

"You really don't know how to relax huh, Adora?" The pinked-haired girl giggles as she tightens her hold on her arm, the purple

cape around her waist flapping with the wind. The sound it makes follows the tune of the waves washing over the boat. It sounds like a symphony in her ears, yearning for those happy moments again.

"It's going to be okay." She feels the gentle weight of the hand from before. She glances over her shoulder and sees a dark-skinned man with armor cut where his midriff can be seen (showing his beautiful abs, unafraid and unbothered by the consequences). He steps closer to her, that reassuring smile still spread on his face. "We're going to do this, Best Friend Squad style."

That knot inside of her unravels a tiny bit. Despite the two of them weighing on either side of her shoulders, she feels light at their touches and words.

"Thank you." That's all she can say but she knows that they understand. All three of them look ahead at their destination, more determined now than before. Suddenly the path seems to show as they look onwards. It fills her heart with something else, loosening any reigns that hold her heart.

* * *

Scorpia's intel instructed that the perimeters of Salineas are heavily guarded but throughout the kingdom, there weren't many soldiers as the rest were still back at King Prime's kingdom. Mermista stated that there were hidden sewers below the walls surrounding Salineas, sewers that Captain Sea Hawk used a lot, she notes. With confirmation from Scorpia that those areas weren't guarded, they planned around that knowledge.

However many they are and however many they outnumber *his* soldiers, she knows just how powerful and cunning Prime is.

Charging in with an armada isn't going to be enough– going in covertly was their best bet.

The small boat was set up and ready for departure. The journey from the ship to the sewers would take just enough time for the sun to peak; a calculated decision. They couldn't risk bringing in too many people, afraid it will blow their cover, plus they need as many people outside for the final battle.

Adora surveys the other ships around them who are waiting patiently. She runs a hand through her hair, a habit she formed after she cut it short. Her bangs fall back to her face once she lowers her hand. It's dark and she knows for sure that in the distance they are invisible to the human eye. It overwhelms her, thinking just how many people are willing to fight with them, with her. Etherians are indeed tired of King Prime's reign, of his many conquests throughout the land, they trust her to lead the rebellion and she wants to give them justice. She clenches her gauntlet hands, the swirling mass inside of her creeping back in. She faces back to the Alliance gathering near where the ladder was hoisted down towards the boat. That tension that had been on the air arises once more as each of them wear hesitant looks, unsure and seemingly unwilling to move. They trust her to lead and so she will.

"Are we all set?" She starts, the moonlight glow illuminating all of them, casting a tiny bit of shadow over them.

"Aye!" A man with a blue jacket pipes up, holding his sabre up in the air. His stash curves with his mouth grinning. "'Tis an adventure this will be!"

There are numerous groans all around where they gather, one louder than the rest. Adora shakes her head and suppresses a smile. Despite the nerves dancing throughout her body, she is thankful for this one small joy piercing through the lingering nerves around the air. It feels normal regardless of the situation. "Remember to watch your aim, there are still survivors in there," she reminds them.

“Don’t worry, with my calculations with wind trajectory and the precise dosage of gunpowder, we won’t do too much damage but enough for the plan to work!” Adora tries not to worry too much at how the scientist cackles while explaining that. She trusts Entrapta (sometimes) and she knows that the scholar would do everything in her power to make this work.

“We’ll leave it to you then,” she says with a genuine smile plastered on her face and her fists loosen. She sees the scientist excitedly smile back, her purple hair seemingly shining brighter in the night, a small twinkle in her eyes, “and Sea Hawk;” she turns her gaze now to the man who held his sabre up high before, stiffening his body as he hears his name. She supposes that she should loosen her mood towards him, despite everything that he is, he’s a fine good captain, “lead them well, captain.” He looks enamored and on the brink of tears.

“And don’t burn any of our own,” remarks a woman next to him, flipping her braided teal hair nonchalantly, hiding a knowing smirk somewhere in her voice.

“No promises!”

“I wish I could come with you guys. This isn’t fair! I’m old enough to fight alongside you!” Adora turns to the smallest of the group, her heart clenches staring at the blue-haired girl. She’s young, too young to be part of this. Adora cast her eyes downward remembering the time when she was that young. Bruised, beaten, a child soldier being held by a string, controlling her every move and every choice. She wants so badly to let this young girl go home and let her be a child. She tries not to think of all the other children who couldn’t be a child because of this war.

“You’re the strongest out of all of them, Frosta.” Adora turns her gaze back up and sees that Glimmer, the pink-haired girl from before, steps forward and places her hands on Frosta’s shoulders. “They need you to protect them.” Glimmer motions to the ship’s crew, scrambling to get ready for the plan ahead.

She sees Frosta perk up, her stance straighter and spear held tighter. Glimmer smiles at her, then for a split second before she surges to hug the girl, her brows furrow and lips frowning. "We'll be back before you know it and when we return, it's going to be a whole new world." She whispers quietly that Adora almost doesn't hear it. Glimmer spoke as if she held onto the words more than her wanting to speak it. "I promise."

Adora gazes back down to the wooden floor. *Protect them*. She once held a promise to protect someone. She only ever promised one person her protection growing up. How did it ever get to her protecting everyone? The grip on her chest tightens harder and the storm inside her stomach raptures tenfold. She failed once before, would she fail again?

* * *

The woods were always eerie, they were told time and time again of scary encounters that happen deep inside the tree infested place. It scared Adora more than it did for her other companion. She walked slowly and carefully, almost tiptoeing with every step afraid of angering any spirits nearby.

"Catra?" She called out to the abyss full of trees unsure if her friend even heard her but sure that she was somewhere nearby. "Please come out, y'know I don't like being here."

She heard some rustling somewhere near her and she hugged herself for protection. In any other circumstances, she wouldn't be caught dead near this place. She felt slightly guilty for feeling this afraid.

For as long as she can remember, she was told that she was destined to be a great knight and as soon as she was able to properly grip a wooden sword with her tiny hands, she began her training. As far as she knew and what she had seen, knights

weren't afraid of anything. they are brave and strong; they do not cower like her at that moment. Yet, even with that knowledge she couldn't help but feel small inside the (haunted) forest. There was nothing she wanted more than to run as far away from this place towards the clearing, where their tiny hut resided.

Despite the fact that her whole body screamed for her to run, she remembered Catra and the thought of Catra sparked something inside of her. Only Catra ever made her feel this brave. She remembered the look the small brunette had before she ran off crying. She looked more terrified than what Adora had felt at that moment. If she felt way worse than what Adora had felt back then– it didn't feel right for her friend to feel that way, Catra doesn't deserve to feel afraid, ever.

With renowned vigor and the thought of her closest companion in her mind, she huffed in confidence, her face changed to determination. She needed to find her friend.

Suddenly, she heard another rustle, but that time she was able to pinpoint that it came from above. She turned her head to the source and saw a sliver of cloth, dangled from a branch that was almost entirely hidden by the leaves that surrounded it.

She grinned, showing her gapped teeth and walked towards the tree the branch was connected to. Catra was a better climber than her, she would always resort to getting on the high ground whenever she and Adora would chase each other around. The first time it happened, Adora tried to follow but ended up falling face-first on the ground, her tooth falling from its place from the impact and Catra cackling at her from above. Shadow Weaver was not happy about that (especially not happy at Catra). The second time was when Catra hid on top of the roof of their little hut, this time Adora successfully (horribly) got to follow her to the top, not wanting to fall again and let Shadow Weaver starve Catra for the night like last time. Eventually, Adora learned through these experiences of chasing Catra. She was still no better but she was able to follow, barely.

She gripped both sides for the trunk, thankful that it wasn't as thick as the rest of the trees around her, her right foot pressed on the base of it, trying to copy Catra when she observed her climbing before. Before she knew it, she found herself hugging the trunk with her whole body and stared at mismatched eyes in a bed of leaves.

"You're going to make yourself fall again stupid," the eyes spoke with a broken voice, one that Adora certainly has heard of before and certainly never wanted to hear ever.

"It's okay! I got this." Adora scrunched her face in concentration, eyeing the branch where Catra sat. Unconsciously her tongue poked out as she tried to reach for the branch while she clung on to the tree for dear life. She leaned in closer and closer, trying to reach for the branch, ignoring how her body inched farther away from the trunk, suddenly to her surprise, she felt herself slipping. Horror etched her face, scared of the outcome, she helplessly racked her brain to stop from slipping when small hands gripped her similarly small hand. Her body hung on the air as her soul ascended out of her body out of fear. She looked up to see a very clearly struggling Catra, trying to pull her up but failing.

They sat breathless on the branch next to each other after she was pulled up.

"You could have gotten yourself hurt!" Catra hissed at her, her eyes were rimmed with red and a little puffy. Remnants of tears still resided on her uniquely mismatched colored eyes.

She made herself small and lowered her head. Somehow, growing up in the hut, every time Adora got hurt whenever she was with Catra, it was always Catra who got punished. She felt guilty every time and wished that it was her who was sent without supper. "I'm sorry," she looked up at her companion again and saw that Catra was still scowling, "I'll be extra extra careful next time!" She grinned showing the gap teeth once again, hoping it would cheer her friend up.

She frowned when the only response she got was her friend turning her head away from her. There was a gust of wind that passed by, rocking the branch where they sat just slightly. Catra drew her cloak closer and that was when Adora heard her whimper.

She softened her gaze at the brunette and let herself form a small smile in understanding.

"It doesn't matter what she says," Adora said, gaining back Catra's attention towards her, "you look out for me and I look out for you nothing really bad can ever happen as long as we have each other."

Catra's face softened and her brows furrowed. "You promise?"

"We're going to protect each other. I promise I'll protect you forever"

* * *

"We should get going, the sun catches on," she speaks up, grounding herself back to the task at hand. Whatever failed promises she made in the past is not going to happen again. She's not going to let it happen again. Failing is not an option.

They all nod, following Adora's lead to climbing down the ladder. She settles herself on the boat, facing towards their destination, careful not to sway too much as the tide rocks the dinghy gently. She is followed by a (very) tall and (very) muscular lady, who sits at the opposite end of the boat from where she is. The boat shakes violently as the woman clumsily sits down, muttering a soft apology as she flumps in her seat, facing towards Adora. They share a look, the woman's short, white hair slightly covers her right eye. Adora breaks her gaze and looks back up from the

ship, feeling slightly unease from the woman. She likes Scorpia, she is kind and seems like a person who would do anything for a friend. She sees herself being close to Scorpia one day but there's still that vice grip on her chest, tighter than what she feels at the moment every time she interacts with the large knight, there is an unspoken tension between them and she figures it's because of their mutual *friend*. She hopes she will be able to talk to her about it someday or talk to her in general, she hates that she feels a tinge of spark every time she sees her and she's tired of being angry.

Maybe when all of this is over.

She hopes that's the case.

The boat trembles once again as one by one they all settle on the boat. A tanned-skinned lady with a beautiful blonde and long hair (lighter than Adora's), sits next to Scorpia. In the row in front of them is the man with a cropped armor, Bow, and Glimmer is beside him. Mermista sits next to her, with the same bored expression she always wears but somewhere deep within those hazel eyes, Adora sees worry.

They didn't know how it happened, it all happened too fast. One moment they were defending Brightmoon from an attack the next they heard the news from surviving Salineans that Salineas had been invaded. Mermista was devastated, of course, she kept blaming herself for leaving her kingdom but Adora and the rest of the Alliance reassured her that they'll get it back. She promised her that they'll save Salineas and end the war. End King Prime for good.

Turning her gaze back up once again, she sees the rest of the alliance who stayed behind look below them from the ship. "Once you see us enter the sewers, start firing," she shouts at them. She hopes this will work, she hopes it would be enough.

"Let's go."

* * *

They reach the wall without a problem. The sun comes up exactly the moment they enter the drainage system of Salineas. Once they disappear inside they hear a massive explosion from the outside, followed by more explosions and the ceiling rumbling above them. Pieces of rumble fall to their heads and some hit their armor. It makes a clanging sound with each rumble that lands.

The tunnel is massive, enough to fit the boat they ride. Inside smells of feces and piss, she tries not to let it deter, holding back the urge to contort her expression. At the end of it is a light, no doubt the entrance to the kingdom. All of them are quiet except for Bow and Glimmer as they row the boat, the sound of water echoes in the tunnel. There is a gnawing feeling deep inside Adora's guts as they draw closer and closer to the light, it eats her up, making her feel more queasy than she already was. This is their only chance, they put everything on the line in this plan. As they reach the end, she gives herself a deep breath hoping to calm her nerves and focus on the mission at hand, ignoring the whiff of stink entering her nose. True to Scorpia's intel, there are no guards patrolling the sewers.

They left the boat inside the tunnel and got in the inner castle without a hitch. The halls are empty and they avoid a few soldiers who are too occupied with running towards where the explosions are. By now the rebels have probably deployed their own warriors to fight, Adora thinks. They start running once they know it is safe, they follow Scorpia and Mermista, guiding them in the castle and avoiding any more soldiers that can see them. The war rages on the outside and it's apparent as the noises only grow more and more hectic.

“This is where we part ways,” Scorpia says between huffs as she stops mid-run. “The remaining surviving Salineans are being held down there.” She points towards a set of stairs, no doubt leading to the basement.

“The throne room is found outside the courtyard. It has a big teal door, you can’t miss it,” instructs Mermista as she steps up, “and since I won’t be there, I want you to give him hell,” she adds with venom in her voice.

Adora nods once, clenches her jaw trying to steady her heart. Suddenly a blur of blonde hugs her. It stuns her in place.

“Keep safe, I believe in you guys.” The woman detaches herself from Adora, smiling at her for an instant before she does the same to Bow and then Glimmer after. “Peace in Etheria will return after this.”

Adora can’t help but smile in spite of herself. There’s still that clenching in her chest, her heart thrumming her insides and the storm in her gut still brews but with the prospect of peace, she can’t help but hope. “Thanks, Perfuma. You guys look out for each other okay?”

“Yeah, also don’t die out there or whatever.” This time Adora laughs at how unconcerned Mermista’s comment sounds.

“Don’t worry your highness, I will personally escort you back to your throne after this.” They grin at each other, an action of reassurance between the two.

“Don’t worry guys, we’re the Best Friend Squad! We’re unstoppable!” Bow pipes up, putting his arms around Adora and Glimmer. So many emotions swell within her. She feels terrified, frantic, and unfocus but at the moment, she can feel the love seeping through. She mirrors the smiles of her companions, big and bright in the dreary kingdom.

“Aw! That’s so cute! I know I haven’t known you all for long and I did try to kill you guys a bunch of times but I love all of you and I

believe in you too!" Suddenly Adora finds herself in another hug but this time all three of them are being crushed with a strong grip from Scorpia, her armor scraping their own and despite the hold and how it constricts her airways, the vice grip that holds her chest loosens from this hug.

"Uh… That's nice Scorp," Glimmer tries saying, trying to gasp for air, "but we need to be alive for us to do the mission."

"Oh right, sorry. I'm a hugger," she sheepishly releases them and gives them a shy smile as an apology. Adora gave her a bright smile to match, hoping to reassure her. Their eyes meet again and Adora falters as she sees Scorpia's smile disappear. She looks at the knight in confusion.

"Before you go– Adora… I–" She looks at Scorpia questioningly, her eyebrows furrow, she watches as the platinum-haired knight took a deep breath. "I know she hurt me and I know she hurt you, but she's just… She's hurt and misunderstood. I'm sure she never wanted all of this."

That grip on Adora's chest tightens tenfold, her throat growing dry. She knows *she's* in here somewhere. It's unavoidable, she knows she is going to fight *her*, one way or another. That was how it is with them now. She knows it's always going to be Adora and *her* but deep inside, the one that she keeps repressing ever since they parted ways long ago, she never wanted to fight her but half of her thinks it's always going to be like this, fighting each other, just like what they were trained and taught for as kids, to fight. The other half wants something else… yet she doesn't want to delve into it. She's tired of trying, tired of hoping but still...

"I know." She feels like she needs to say more, feels obligated to. But how can you begin to describe the inner battle that roots deep inside of you every time you think of *her*? She is never good with words, she can never articulate well enough what she really wants to say. It always comes out wrong and misinterpreted. But she doesn't have a chance to say anything else.

"You guys should go, we'll alert the rebellion once we rescued the survivors," Scorpia cuts through her train of thought, giving her a sympathetic look and saving her from herself, "the next time we'll see you, it's going to be a whole new world out there."

* * *

They walk carefully through the halls of Salinea's castle, despite the roaring battle that's taking place outside, the castle seems to be quiet, too quiet.

Adora unsheathes her sword as a precaution. Something doesn't feel right. As they walk closer and closer to the courtyard, she expects to encounter some guards. The battle wages on, outside but surely they wouldn't leave their king unattended. It was odd for her. She can sense that something bad is going to happen, her heart rate starts beating fast and adrenaline surges through her entire body. Bow and Glimmer follow her lead, Glimmer clutching her spear with both hands aiming it in front of her and Bow grabbing his bow that slung around his body, taking an arrow out of his arrow bag.

Swiftly, Adora stops on her tracks, there's a sound of movement somewhere. It sounds familiar. She holds her sword with both hands, gripping tightly. She focuses on the surroundings around her, trying to ignore the explosions and screams still roaring outside.

Before she can further investigate, there is a flash of movement above her, only noticing it for a split second before she's faced with the blurry motion she saw. A dagger aims towards her throat and she barely has time to block it with her sword but manages to do so. In no time, the dagger moves once again, this time she's able to follow their momentum and is also able to block the

incoming attack aiming towards her stomach. Behind her, she hears grunts and objects clashing. An ambush.

“Fuck! Of course, she’d send her hounds at us.” She hears Glimmer’s disgruntling whine from behind her as she manages to dodge yet another attack. She’s playing defensive, it’s hard to attack someone this fast, she knows this by experience. In the corner of her eye, she sees another blur of motion coming towards her while she’s holding off yet another attack from her opponent. She’s ready to face the newcomer when they suddenly drop dead, an arrow sticking out of their chest.

“Thanks,” she pauses as she let out a grunt while blocking another attack from the incoming dagger, “Bow,” she continues with a nod towards the archer. She ducks, seeing the dagger aim for her head and that’s when she sees her opportunity to attack, in one swift motion, she swings her sword, slashing through her attacker's stomach, easily cutting through the armorless warrior.

“How many Bow?” She stands back up, turning away from the body dropping and blocking yet another attack from a new opponent. She grabs the wrist in time with their blades clashing, keeping them in place as she draws her arm back where she holds her sword and punches the new opponent right on the face, successfully subduing them.

“Twenty at most.” She sees him blurt out a response to her, as he rapidly fires away arrow after arrow, protecting her and Glimmer’s back. She slashes yet another warrior as they run towards her when the body drops she sees Glimmer, twirling her spear and successfully protecting herself from incoming throw-knives, the knives fall on the ground, the sound echoing through the hallways, melding well with the sound of their own frustration in battle.

She knows these moves, she’s studied them and she knows them by heart. They’re familiar but also unfamiliar. These are rogues, no doubt they are *her* rogues. She swats an incoming throw-knife directed at her but fails to handle the rest of the flying knives.

One grazes her cheeks, drawing blood from it and the other hit her square on the shoulder blade, she feels it sting on impact. She sees a few more flying towards her but she rolls out of the way, slashing the legs of a rogue once she stops. She takes out the dagger from her shoulder blade and throws it back to the source, hitting her target. Blood spills out once she removes the sharp object, drenching her armor.

They faced them before, countless times actually. She can't help but think that they get stronger and stronger with every encounter. There aren't many Rogues in Etheria but ever since she joined the rebellion, there's a resurgence of them. They are fast, cunning, and almost undetectable when they're trying to be stealthy. Even if Adora is one of the quicker knights, she can never keep up with a Rogue's attack. They are a flurry of slashes and calculated hits.

She blocks yet another dagger but this time the rogue brings another dagger out, ready to stab her lower torso, she quickly catches their hand, the tip of the dagger mere inches from the least protected part of her armor. Her hands are tied and she struggles to move freely. With quick thinking she tries to twirl the rogue around, turning with them, their back now pressed at the front of Adora's body. She inches her sword closer to the rogue's neck but they retaliate by blocking it with their dagger. She lets out a low snarl as she struggles.

"Bow!" The archer looks towards her, immediately understanding. He pulls back his bow and fires an arrow towards them. It hit right on the rogue's chest, making them limp instantly from her hold. She lets go of their body and lets it drop to the floor with a sigh. She surveys her surroundings, seeing several bodies on the floor. She looks towards Glimmer, as she clutches at her wounded shoulder, putting pressure to stop the bleeding, just in time to see her friend strike at her opponent, cutting through their body with her staff.

"I think that's all of them," Glimmer states after straightening her stance. They are all breathing heavily. She sheathes her sword

back to its cover, her body was slightly sore. Inside her armor, she can feel sweat dripping through her body. Bloodstains on her armor (most likely a mixture of hers and whoever she fought). She runs her hand through her damp hair this time her bangs stay put, giving her a slick back hairdo with a few strands straying away and falling to her face.

She grabs the arrow from the body she just dropped and is about to give it to Bow when suddenly she sees the incoming dagger flying towards him. It hit him where his armor lacked. She sees him look down where he is hit then collapses on the ground, his bow makes a clunking sound as it falls from his grasp.

"Bow!" Glimmer and she screams in unison. She is about to run towards him but then sees another dagger fly towards them, she draws her sword out just in time to slash it away, she gets ready to surge towards him when a spear flies by hitting the rogue right on the head.

She stands and watches as Glimmer runs towards Bow after throwing her spear. Glimmer kneels and places his head on her knees. Bow winces at the movement then gives out a huge grin towards them.

"I'm fine, I'm fine!" He did not look fine.

"It doesn't look fatal but you're going to lose a lot of blood soon." The pink-haired warrior looks to her for guidance, tears forming in her eyes. Adora stands still, still feeling the adrenaline rush through her.

"We can't–" Glimmer tears her eyes off of Adora as she speaks. She looks back at Bow, who is breathing through the pain. "We have to go back. Bow's fatally injured and your shoulder doesn't look fine. We can't face him like this. We have to retreat, at least back to the ship."

Bow tries to stand up but ends up moaning in pain, Glimmer catches him quickly. "She's right, we still have a chance to regroup

with the rest before they get back to the ship with the boat."

She looks at them both. Glimmer takes hold of Bow as he struggles to get up, the blood seeping from his wound down to his armored legs. The dagger still lodges deep inside of him, stopping him from bleeding more. This isn't how it was supposed to go. Injury in battle is inevitable and they know that there are bound to be guards waiting for them outside where King Prime is but they're supposed to defeat him together. She doesn't know if there is going to be any more opportunities like this.

The battle wages on the outside, they can hear the explosion and screams of soldiers. She tries hard not to think about it. She tries not to think about the number of bodies that fall outside or if any of the alliance got injured or worse. She tries not to think about what will happen to them next if they retreat and what Prime would do. They're fighting a losing war. This is their one chance of turning the tides towards them. They gave their everything to this and this is their only opportunity.

This was how it was always going to end

"Go." When she was a child, she never really had a choice about what she wanted to do in life. She was always told that she was going to be a great knight that would serve the greater good of Etheria. Time and time again she is always reminded of her destiny to be the great knight. "Go back to the boat, I'll stay here and finish it." For the greater good of Etheria.

"Adora, what are you talking about?" She softens her gaze at the pair, for a split moment she doesn't see two warriors holding on for dear life but two lovers holding on to their future.

"I love you guys so much. I don't think I can ever make it this far without you two. Thank you for giving me a life I didn't know I wanted, thank you for giving me a second chance. I'll see you at the wedding okay?" She grins shakily, holding on to the tears she knows is dreading to fall. They were never supposed to be here, it

was always just going to be her. “This is our last chance, I have to do this alone and you have to go.”

“Adora, no! You don’t need to do this!” She stares at them one last time, Bow struggling to get those words out. She gives them one last smile before turning around and starts running towards the courtyard, not giving them a chance to stop her.

“Adora!”

* * *

“Adora. What is that childish thing you are reading?” A gloomy shadow obscured the light that Catra and Adora had.

They had sneaked down to where the fireplace was inside their tiny hut. All the other children were asleep as the moon was at its peak. The only light that illuminated the house was the crackling fire of wood, it also kept them warm in these snowy times. They didn’t expect to be caught, these two were always having their own adventures, living in a fantasy world where they can be free unlike where they really are.

Adora stiffened from where she sat, gripping the book at hand. She felt Catra straightened herself and the warmth from her shoulder disappeared.

“It’s just a story about horses and adventure. I’m sorry we snuck out so late, Shadow Weaver. We’ll go back to bed.” She closed the book she was holding and grabbed Catra’s wrist, ready to bring them up and head upstairs. She didn’t want to stay any longer and anger Shadow Weaver.

She was stopped with a cold hand on her shoulder. She looked up at the woman with a silk mask covering her mouth. Her expression was hidden but her eyes said everything. Adora gulped

and she could feel Catra shiver beside her. "And where did you get this... book?" Shadow Weaver snatched the book from her grasp and examined it.

Catra came back to the hut while Adora was tasked to tend the garden. Catra had a satchel around her while also carrying a stack of wood on both arms. Shadow Weaver was out and had business in a town near them. When they both settled in the hut, both equally dirty and covered with sweat from the chores they did, Catra revealed that she found the book laying on the ground inside the woods while she was foraging.

"I found it, on the road near here." Shadow Weaver merely squinted at her then to the horror of Adora, turned her gaze to Catra.

Without warning, she grabbed Catra forcefully by the hair and yanked her away from Adora. "Why are you lying for her Adora? This insolent child has corrupted you." Catra yelled from the pain and she started crying, begging to be put down.

"No! Shadow Weaver! I'm telling the truth, It was me! It was me!" She shot up and held Shadow Weaver's arm that held Catra, hoping to make her stop. She started sobbing, desperate for the safety of her friend.

Shadow Weaver let go of Catra's hair, pushing her slightly back then cupped Adora's cheeks as tears ran down from it. "Oh Adora, you must not let these childish things get you. Someday you're going to live in a castle and have the honor of protecting our king. This is what you were born to do. You're going to save us from this place, Adora. Only you can save us."

Still trembling, she stared at Shadow Weaver. Her words struck a string inside of her. There was a lodge inside her throat as she struggled to swallow whatever it was that wanted to resurface. Shadow Weaver removed her cold hands from her cheek, a ghost of chill still residing even after it was removed.

“Go along now. You have a day full of training,” Shadow Weaver then turned to Catra who has stopped weeping on the floor, her head down and hair covering her face, “both of you.”

Adora quickly got to Catra’s side and helped her up, when the girl looked up at her, her heart shattered. She held on to the brunette tightly and started leading them upstairs.

“Oh, and Adora,” she turned back to their guardian, heart beating fast, “forget about these,” she pauses looking at the book she held, “childish fantasies. You need only one thing on your mind.” She saw her throw the book over the fire, a small blaze of explosion erupted as the book landed on the fire. She looked longingly at it for a second then went back to leading her and Catra back to bed.

* * *

She stops running as soon as she reaches outside. She walks the hallway, leading to the courtyard, flowers overgrowing through the window. She walks with stride and every step she takes, her armor would clink like bells. Around the corner of this hall, she would find the teal door that Mermista instructed. Around the corner of this hall, she would find her destiny.

But there’s someone else she knows is waiting for her around the corner. Her gut tells her so.

There, leaning on those giant teal doors is a woman. Patiently waiting, no doubt waiting for the blonde knight. Her hood covers her face, two swords poke out from her back. They’re in the courtyard. The sun, now fully up, shining through them. At the center of the courtyard is a round marbled floor that had artwork on it, it is covered with fallen debris of nearby structures, surrounding it are vegetation on pots of all kinds. There are stairs that lead to the doors and that leads to her.

In any other circumstances, Adora could say that it is a beautiful sight.

“Hey, Adora.” The woman removes her hood, revealing her grinning face and messily tied hair. For a moment, that vice grip that holds Adora’s chest loosens just enough for her heart to drop to the pit of her stomach. “It seems like you were enjoying yourself out there.”

“You have your rogues to thank for that,” she retorts back, now feeling the sting on her shoulder blades. She clutches her sword on her better arm, stepping closer to the woman. She feels the rubble of dirt under her feet as she takes a step. “You did a number on all of us I must say but you really thought I could be stopped that easily?”

“They were supposed to stop all of you.” The woman moved closer too, “but I guess if you want things done, you do it yourself.”

They meet on the borders of the circle. Circling and not keeping their eyes away from each other. They are doing a dance that they are oh so familiar with. Familiarity rushes through Adora.

“They seem out of practice. They usually have better aim.” They stop and study each other's movements. The woman’s grin seems to fade and is now wearing a scowl on her face.

“They never miss.” Adora watches as the rogue in front of her draws out both her blades from her back. She lowers her stance, a stance that shows determination and ferociousness. Adora has never seen this side of her before. The woman is always sly and playful. Adora can feel her heart that fell on the pit of her stomach drilling further down the longer she stares at her foe. Something tells her that this is not going to end well for one of them and she’s afraid that one of them might do something they’ll regret. This dance seems different from all the other dances they did.

I’m sure she never wanted all of this.

“Catra.” She looks at the woman, her eyes pleading, hoping it would get through to her. “You don’t have to do this, please.” She likes to believe that she still knows this woman, but somewhere, within the realms of the space they have on this circle of marble, the woman staring back at her is a stranger in the body of someone from her past.

“If I’m not going to stop you, then who will Adora?” She stiffens at the words that left Catra’s mouth. Somehow, it sounds different than a threat. She isn’t sure if it’s because of the throbbing pain from her shoulder or if she really heard pleading behind Catra’s voice. All she wanted at that moment was to lower her ground and walk away with her. It’s always *her*.

She doesn’t get to indulge her fantasies as her opponent in front of her suddenly jumps a few meters off the air, a puff of dust emerges below her feet, her blades raise above her head and ready to strike Adora. She steps back to brace herself from the impact as she raises her own sword to protect herself from the attack. With a loud clanging sound as Catra’s two blades clash with Adora’s towering sword.

“Stop fighting, Adora.” Their faces are inches apart, divided by their swords.

“Never.” With one swift movement, she swings her sword with enough force to draw Catra away from her body but Catra is quick to recover as she spins around to catch her momentum and strikes at her again, aiming Adora’s midriff. There’s another clang as her sword clashes with the blade once again and another as Catra is quick at work to get as many blows as she could.

Both of them aren’t holding back, Adora can sense that there’s something bigger at stake for Catra as it is for her. It isn’t like how they fought before or even how they sparred as kids. Each strike they give to each other is given with intent. She isn’t sure what it is for Catra and she isn’t sure what it is for her either but this battle isn’t like any other battles they had.

* * *

"What? The mighty She-ra can't keep up with my speed?" She dodged yet another attack from the brunette but was too slow to dodge the other wooden sword that her opponent held. It smacked her on her right arm, not enough to wound her but enough to show a slight bruising later, which emitted a giggle from Catra.

"That's not fair Catra! Knights don't have two swords." She shielded herself to yet another quick attack from Catra.

"Yeah well, what if I don't want to be a stupid knight like you?" She pushed herself away from Catra, giving herself a distance to assess her next move. Catra was holding two wooden swords with a great big grin on her face. There was a glint in her eyes, one that shows just how much fun she's going to have. She twirled them around with her hands, daunting Adora. "Not all of us have a hero-complex, Adora."

"I do not have a hero-complex!" She lunged forward, both hands holding a tight grip of her wooden sword. She aimed at the top of Catra's head.

* * *

Her broadsword wedges between Catra's blade, stopping her attack. Her body is tense and she grunts to put more pressure towards the rogue, it's difficult with only one hand wielding her sword. Catra is growling at her, those heterochromatic eyes glaring up at her.

“Why do you always have to play the hero Adora? Why did you have to come here?” Their faces are close enough that Adora can feel the hot breath of Catra as she speaks. She can see every detail of her face, the number of freckles that are beautifully painted on her skin, the darkness around her eyes, a few scars that plaster in some parts of her face, the dip of her cheeks, showing her high cheekbone, she can even smell her scent this close. For a moment, just for a moment, she sees something inside of Catra, an emotion she hasn’t seen in a long time. For that brief moment, she wishes it would be different.

“This is my destiny, Catra.”

“Destiny? Fuck, Adora!” She is suddenly stumbling back, feeling a pang of pain on her chest as she is kicked by Catra with such force that made her armor dent a little. The armor itself does little help to protect her as it helped with the impact of the kick. She has to take a few deep breaths to catch some air, she might have a broken rib after that kick. She looks up, clutching her chest, ready to counter but stops as she meets Catra’s gaze. “Why does it always have to be you!”

“I-” She can’t breathe properly and it isn’t just because her ribs are currently compressing her lungs but seeing Catra like this. It’s different. “I have no choice.”

* * *

“Do you really want to be a knight, Adora?” They were breathing heavily, they lost track of time on how long they sparred. Sweat dripped their foreheads and the clothes on their back stuck to their skin.

Adora stepped back and twisted her body, getting momentum for another blow, she targeted Catra’s leg, hoping to trip her but she was quick enough to dodge, leaving Adora to swing at the air and

letting her be in a vulnerable position. With a loud slap, she was hit again by Catra, letting Adora stagger to the side.

"It's what I've been training my whole life, it's what I'm good at," she huffed. She tried attacking once more but Catra deflected her, their bodies were once again close to each other.

"But what do you want?"

* * *

She can feel herself being frustrated. There are cuts on her armor and some pierce right through it. The throbbing on her shoulder was getting worse and the weight of her protective piece was getting to her. But mostly, she's so frustrated with the things that Catra says. Catra has always loved playing mind games but this feels different and it frustrates her because she doesn't know if that is the goal for Catra or is it really different.

She remembers a time where she can read Catra like a book. One look, through her eyes and she, knows what Catra needs and what Catra wants but right now, as she stares at those blue and brown eyes all she sees is… all she sees is… What does she see?

She grips her sword with exasperation and aggressively slides her sword out of the grasp that Catra has it in between her double blade, a whistle of a sound, slices through the dead air as she does. Her heart is pumping with anger and frustration. "Enough!"

She draws her sword back and swings it back towards Catra. As she expects, she blocks it and that's when Adora sees her opening. She lifts her injured arm, ignoring the burn that she feels on her shoulder as she does, and strikes Catra with a powerful punch. There's a loud thumping noise and her armor vibrates at the impact. She feels the adrenaline course through her body more than she feels the throbbing on her shoulder. She knows she

is bleeding again but is too preoccupied with how Catra stumbles back, with her face dripping with blood from Adora's metal gloved fist. Catra's face is etched with surprise, her body wide open for an attack.

She takes the opportunity, taking quick strides then swings her sword across the rogue's body, slashing through her unprotected cloak. It's deep enough to bleed through Catra's already red clothes but not deep enough to be fatal. She uses her other hand to grip her sword with both hands, swinging it again towards Catra, her opponent tries to block but is futile as Adora's hit is stronger, causing one of her blades to fly out of her grasp. The blade lands a few distances away from them, a loud noise is heard as it drops on the ground. Catra is looking more and more frantic, her eyes are roaming around the place before it lands back to Adora's piercing blue ones.

Catra surges forward, ready for another attack but Adora is quicker this time punching her successfully on the gut and also hitting the new wound that Adora gave. Catra wobbles backward, wheezing for air. She clutches her stomach as blood drips on her face where Adora had punched her before. She looks menacingly at Adora, her canines out as she grits her teeth.

"Fuck you, Adora."

* * *

Her eyes were blinded by the dirt that flew towards her. Catra had dragged her sword on the ground throwing a gust of dirt towards her. She was momentarily blinded, her eyes stinging.

"That's foul Catra!" She tried to focus on her hearing, tried to pinpoint any sound that Catra would make but the brunette was too silent and quick that Adora failed to dodge a hit from her foe.

"There are no rules in battle princess!" She felt another hit on her right shoulder, feeling the wind blowing as Catra went past her. She could hear footsteps circling her as if she were a prey being hunted by a predator. She couldn't pinpoint the exact source where the noise came from but she tried to focus on them.

"This is low, even for you Catra." She craned her neck trying to find the source of the noises around her. She could hear the branches being snapped, rocks being thrown, and rushing footsteps circle around. Her eyes still stung from the dirt and her tears didn't help subside the pain, it only made it worse. "I can't imagine fighting against you in a real battle, you're such a little brat."

Suddenly she felt heat behind her, freezing her in her place when she felt it. "You know nothing is too low for me, Adora." The hot breath of Catra tingled against her ears and the hairs on the back of her neck stood at the sensation. Her breath hitched at how close Catra felt, she could almost feel their body touching. She twisted around hoping to catch her friend off guard but all she heard was a swooshing noise as she hit the air. A giggling sound emitted somewhere, she tried so carefully opening her eyes but the pain still resides and darkness still welcomes her. That giggle kept ringing in her ears, it made her heart flutter from hearing it.

"Besides," she heard the girl say nearby, "we'll always be on the same team! Can you imagine? With my cunning reflexes and quick thinking, and your brute strength and tactical mind, we'd be unstoppable together!"

She can't help herself but grin at the thought. Those giggles were so infectious that she stopped herself from laughing with her. "You'll always fight with me by my side?"

"Always!" The voice now sounds distant and she worries that Catra had left somehow. She furrowed her brows in worry.

"Together?" That's when she felt a weight drop on her with a loud thud and giggles on her back. She almost fell forward but caught

herself from falling. She felt a pair of warm hands cover her eyes then was removed almost as quickly as it was there, the dirt removing with them. She looked over to see a laughing Catra, steadying herself by wrapping herself on Adora's neck.

"Together!"

"Catra!" She laughed trying to shake her away. Joyous laughter pierced through their small clearing where their hut resides.

* * *

"Catra!" She grits the rogue's blade on her neck, drawing blood from it. "You never change do you." She claws behind her, trying to get the warrior off of her but fails because of the restraints of her armor. Her eyes full of dirt from the rubble below their feet.

"Yeah, I'm still a little brat," hisses Catra near her ear. It's a different sensation. It isn't warm like before but boiling hot. It burns her very core instead of comforting her through the winter. The blade keeps going deeper as she keeps struggling, her lungs feel like collapsing from the added weight and her shoulder is searing with pain.

Feeling more and more irritated at the position they are in, Adora stops her movement abruptly. She takes a deep breath then lurches forward, bringing Catra with her and successfully throwing her away, towards the stairs that lead to the door. There's a cracking noise when she lands that makes Adora flinch.

She kneels in her place for a moment, getting more air into her lungs. Her bangs covering her face. She hears Catra moaning and breathing heavily in front of her. She struggles to bring herself up, pain coursing through her body. She unsteadily walks towards where Catra's body lay, forcing her eyes to open, clutching her stomach and catching her breath.

Adora brings her sword and points it at Catra's neck, she stiffens when their eyes meet, her own widen at how defeated Catra looks.

"He's going to kill you," Catra whispers barely audible.

There's that look again, that indescribable look she saw earlier but this time more pronounced.

"Please," Adora's hand starts to shake at Catra's words, "don't go in there. He's going to kill you." She's taken aback by the rogue's words, not expecting the tone on her voice.

She steadies herself and scowls at Catra. "Like you weren't just trying to kill me a minute ago?!" She grips her sword tighter and lets the tip closer to Catra's neck, now touching her skin. "Afraid I'm going to kill your master?"

Catra's eyes suddenly burn with anger at her words, she spits blood towards her feet but Adora doesn't falter her stance. "I'm trying to help you! Would you look at yourself?!" Catra huffs then wince when she breathes.

And for the first time, Adora took account of how Catra looks. Her body is covered in bruises, there's a rip on her shirt and a streak of blood can be seen through it. Her hair coming loose from the ponytail she wears. Every breath she takes, it's like she's drowning, gasping for air. There's blood on her mouth and blood dripping from her cheek where it also starts changing color. For the first time that she's seen her, Catra looks defeated.

She feels her body collapsing at the thought. Her own aching body catching up to her.

When did it start being like this?

"Catra." Her heart is yet again found deep inside her pit. She feels the tears bursting out of her and this time she lets them, too tired of it all. "Catra."

When did we start being like this?

“I want you to come home. There’s still a chance for you.” She can see Catra’s eyes widening then looks down at the ground. Adora lowers her sword, the tip of it touches the ground with a loud noise. “When all this is over–” she hesitates, trying to find Catra’s gaze, when she sees those mismatched eyes again she continues. “When all this is over, there’s a home for you in Brightmoon. You’ll always be accepted there, so please, come home.”

“Why do you care? I know you hate me.” Catra looks down at the ground again, her own tears showing as well. It makes Adora angry but not at her, it makes her angry at the thought that Catra thinks she’s mad at her when in fact–

“I never hated you.” Catra’s head snaps back at this and their eyes meet again and for a moment it’s just the two of them.

Adora sighs. There’s still something lingering at the back of Adora’s mind. Something at the tip of her tongue, but as she looks at Catra and sees how much damage she made to her, she bites her tongue and starts walking away.

Maybe in another time...

“Adora, please don’t go. You don’t have to do this!” She tries not to look back and she tries not to stop herself.

“I have no choice Catra.”

“You always have a choice.” This time, she dares to look back and almost regrets it instantly. The hurt on Catra’s eyes is almost enough for her to stay but it has to be this way. She smiles sadly at her.

“No, I don’t.”

When did we start hurting each other?

* * *

"I'm sorry Catra. I didn't mean to hit you that hard." She held Catra's red-marked hand so gently with her tiny ones. Her friend was sniffling and wincing whenever Adora would hold her hand too tightly.

They were sparring, as per Shadow Weaver's instructions. They were barely bigger than the wooden swords they used. Whenever they would train, it would always escalate. Shadow Weaver kept telling them it was to prepare them for the future, for them to be stronger.

But Adora never really wanted to hurt Catra. She never expected to be on opposing sides as Catra during these training sessions, they always did everything together.

"I shouldn't have gone all out, I'm sorry," Adora said with a pout, rubbing Catra's hand gently. She heard her friend sniffle a little and when she looked up she saw Catra rubbing her nose at the back of her hand.

"It's okay, Shadow Weaver said never hold back when fighting." Adora knew that she ingrained it in her head the last time they trained. She was reprimanded for being soft but still, it didn't feel right for Adora.

"Well, she's not here! We don't need to do everything she says when she's not here." she gently squeezed Catra's hand and looked up at her with a grin on her face. "We can always just have fun when she's away!"

"Really?" Catra asked so softly, her tears fading away. "No more hurting each other?"

An idea then popped up in her mind, something that she saw a knight do one time. She kissed the red mark on Catra's injured hand so gently, hoping the kiss alone will heal her. "No, we'll never hurt each other again."

* * *

As soon as she enters the teal doors, she is greeted by an empty room except for a large teal throne and a barrel off to the right of the throne. King Prime sits patiently on the throne, his sword stands, piercing the floor, leaning against the armrest of the throne, green liquid dripping on the floor.

She takes a tentative step forward, her steel shoes clicking on the hard floor.

"Ah yes, you've finally arrived. Your Catra did say you will, I was hoping she would deal with you herself but it seems that little sister has entertained you well enough." He scans her up and down, smiling ever so creepily. She feels her hairs stand by the way he looks at her and she almost covers herself with her arms but she doesn't want to give him the satisfaction of knowing that he creeps her out.

She can still hear the explosions coming from outside, it seems to be closer than it was before. She wonders if the rest of the Alliance rescued the survivors and got back to the ship already. She wonders if Glimmer and Bow got there in time to escape. She doesn't want to think too hard on it, not wanting to be distracted and falter. She knows she's spiraling, of course, she can feel the lump on her throat as she stares up at him. She hates how calm he looks and how his robes are still pristine and white, unharmed, and untouched, unlike the people that suffered because of him.

"Quite a ruckus you and your friends made." He stands up so slowly that it irks Adora. He lifts his sword, the green liquid still

dripping from it. “It’s a shame, all this effort,” he walks towards where the barrel is, “all this needless waste,” he raises his sword on top of the opening of the barrel, “and for what?” He dips his sword in for a few seconds while still looking at Adora with that creepy smile. He pulls it out and comes more dripping green liquid, his smile fades and his face turns serious. “Nothing.”

Adora grips her sword in anger. She eyes the green goo that drips from his sword, she recalls a fallen soldier being unlucky enough to face Prime. She knows why he’s so dangerous, not only is he a master swordsman but it’s also because of the said goo. One little cut is all it takes to end your life. A synthetic, so potent and so mysterious that even Entrapta can’t figure it out. She remembers the last time she went face to face with him, she barely got out alive, being brash and naive at the time to attack head-on without thinking.

This time she knows and waits for him to move.

“Tell me, Adora. Was it worth it? Risking everything to be here, only to fail?” She’s sure that her hands are turning white from the vice grip she has on her sword’s handle.

“I won’t fail. You don’t know what I’m capable of.” She raises her other arm and holds her sword with both hands. Despite the pain bursting through her shoulders, she feels determined to finish this once and for all.

He examines his newly covered sword, that smile still on his face. “Oh, but I do.” He springs towards her, his white robe and equally white hair flowing behind him. She staggers at the impact of his sword against her sword. The force is so powerful that she almost fell. She grits her teeth as the green liquid drops to her armor. She pushes herself off of him, creating distance between them. It’s dangerous to fight him up close.

She circles around him, her sword covering her face for protection and waiting for his next move.

“You miscalculated this plan. There is no outcome to this that you will come out as the victor. You will die, just like the rest of your people!” He pounces towards her again, sword swinging. She dodges just in time but she doesn't have time to pause and rest as he strikes another attack towards her and another and another. Every time, Adora dodges and jumps out of the way, barely able to use her sword. She tries to find an opening but fails to focus on the incoming flurry of attacks. He isn’t as fast as Catra but he’s fast enough to keep Adora on her toes. She can’t risk being too close to him, especially with her having too many open wounds at the moment.

She can feel her body taking a toll on her. As she moves more and more, the pain increases and the breathing gets harder. Her sword collides with Prime, drawing her closer to him.

“Accept your faith.” She clenches her jaw and draws one of her hands back, ready to punch him but as it flies towards him, he catches it mid-air, his smile only growing. “Your Catra was right. You are so predictable.”

He pushes her a little, detaching his sword away from hers and throwing her arm away from him. In one swift movement, he uses the arm that held her to punch her where Catra had kicked her on the chest. Leaving a bigger dent on her armor and larger crack on her ribs. She wheezes for air as her chest tightens from the impact. Before she can recover, she is met by another punch this time on her face, she plummets down, still gasping for air. She feels a foot pushing her body to face the ceiling and when she tries to sit up and counter, his foot, steps on the wound on her shoulder. She cries out in pain from the pressure she feels.

“So this was supposed to be the mighty She-ra that would protect me,” he says as he puts more pressure on her wound, the point on his boot, digging further and further in her shoulder, “such a pity, you would have been an excellent royal guard.” His sword presses on Adora’s unwounded cheek, the cold metal, and liquid piercing through her skin.

All she can hear now is the deafening silence. She wants to feel the tremble of her demise but she feels none. She feels herself slipping away.

"Oh, well. Such things are replaceable." He lowers himself closer to her, the blade of his sword now facing her skin. "Just like your Catra."

I promise I'll protect you forever.

She takes a sharp breath. There's an electrifying feeling coursing through her body, a reminder. With newfound vigor, she tries to push the blade away from her face using her sword with what little fight she has left. It seems futile and impossible but it doesn't matter, she has to try, if not for herself then for the people fighting outside the castle, for the rebellion, for the people of Etheria, for her friends and for, Catra. She'll fight for them.

"How entertaining to see you try. I'm thoroughly amused but," he lets the blade press deeper into Adora's cheek, "all good things must come to an end. Goodbye, She-ra."

There's a light that flashes in her vision. She sees all her friends smiling and laughing with her, the light feeling she felt when she's with them. She sees all the places she's ever been and how beautiful they all look. She sees the sun rising as she sits on a rooftop with Catra. In these moments, she feels love. In her last breath, she remembers the feeling of love…

When all of a sudden she hears a scream echo through the room. She blinks open her eyes and sees Catra falling towards them. In one swoop, she slashes Prime's back with her two blades, then lands a few distances beside them, rolling to stop her fall.

Adora is distraught at the events and her brain a jumbled mess. She sees King Prime jostle forward from the impact, his sword now removes from her skin. With her brain still processing, she kicks herself away from Prime, instincts kicking in for survival. She

turns to see Catra, smirking and raggedly breathing, her two swords propping herself up and is kneeling with one knee.

"You wretched traitor!" She turns her attention to Prime and sees him trying to eye his new wound at his back. No one has ever wounded him, he is told to be a God. King Prime the untouchable.

"You're not so bad yourself," Catra says then jumps out of the way to dodge an incoming attack from Prime, his moves seem less calculated than before anger fuming all over his face. "Adora! If you want to be a hero so badly get your ass back up and fight!"

Catra dodges another onslaught of attack from Prime. Adora's shoulder is searing with pain that she feels like it's going to remove itself from her but she feels the surge of adrenaline bubbling inside her again as she sees Catra fight. Her heart pumps and she gulps up as much air as she needs before standing up.

She sees Prime about to give another blow at Catra and she rushes in just in time to block the oncoming attack, their swords clashing. Adora's heart, beats even further, standing in front of Catra and protecting her. There's movement behind her and Catra emerges from Adora, slitting Prime on the chest. He grunts from the attack and tries to swing his sword again but Adora is quicker than him, parrying his swing giving Catra another opening to attack.

Their moves push and pull with each other as if they are dancing a duet. It's a familiar dance that Adora quickly follows, it's more familiar than the dance they did before. Despite their broken bodies, they feel stronger together. Giving strength to the weakened parts of each other.

Prime calms himself after a moment. For the first time in the lifetime of her knowing Prime, he's breathless. His body is covered with blood, his white robe almost thoroughly red. His breathing is unequal and his hair disheveled. What was once an ethereal king now bathes in his own blood.

But she knows her and Catra aren't in good shape either. They're breathing hard and their wounds are catching up. Adora knows that they can't keep this up and no matter how many hits they got on King Prime, he's still in better shape than them.

She looks over to Catra again, hunched over slightly, there's blood at the corner of her mouth. She's breathing unevenly like Adora but written all over her face screams "fight". Catra has always been a fighter, looking at her swells something inside Adora. It motivates her.

"What a quaint sight. A beautiful partnership if I do say so myself." Her attention goes back to Prime, who is eyeing them carefully. She grips her sword tightly, waiting for any movement. Her shoulder is panging with pain, it's like a drum beat, pounding every second. "But I see all, I know all!"

He charges in, hands, on his sword ready to swing at them. Adora waits until he's close enough to move. One more step and Prime is in front of Adora, whose sword thrust high, ready to block the incoming attack. Adora's vision slows down. She can see Prime's sword almost colliding with hers but for a split second and agonizingly slow for her, she sees him sidestep at the last minute, twisting his body to do a 360 turn away from her, the liquid on his sword splashes on her armor. That's when she catches his eyes and where it gazes. Her blood runs cold as she follows his line of sight, passing where she is, he targets Catra.

"Catra!"

* * *

She dashed towards the tree as fast as she could, her wooden sword still on her hand. She reached just in time to catch the fallen brunette on her arms, falling down on the ground from the collision.

“Catra! What was that?” She looked up at her friend with an irritated look.

“You should have seen your face,” Catra giggled, still on top of Adora, “Ah! No! Betrayal!”

“You could have gotten seriously hurt!” She could feel her friend settling comfortably further on top of her. It felt nice and warm, in contrast to the cool air.

“You saved me, didn’t you? It’s fine!” Catra calms herself from giggling, now grinning at Adora.

“I’m not always going to be here to save you.”

She felt a sharp point on her forehead, Catra’s finger was pointed on it, she was wearing a smirk on her face and there was a glint on her eyes. “I doubt it.”

It scares Adora just how much she’s willing to do anything for this girl. Growing up they didn’t really have much and other kids come and go but what’s constant with her life was always Catra. All those years that they pushed through life together, beating any odds that came their way. It scares her just how much she wants to give up everything she knows just for this girl but she can’t do that. She can’t let herself succumb to what she wants, not when she’s needed elsewhere and not when she has to be the person she needs to be. She wants to though. She wants Catra, she wants her to be safe and happy, always.

* * *

The sword lodges deep inside of her. She can feel the icky green goo, dripping inside of her. She looks down expecting to feel pain but all she feels is numbness coursing through her entire body. It

penetrates just below her left breast, she can taste iron in her mouth.

She looks up at the King, an inexpressible expression forms on his face. She gives him a broken smile as she clutches her sword. His hands are frozen still, holding the hilt of his sword, she sees her chance, her only chance. “You miscalculated.” She musters up what little energy she has left, screaming from the strain of her body and thrust up stabbing him where his abdomen is. He sputters out blood, landing some on her as he mumbles out sounds of disbelief. He lets go of his hold on her, setting her free. The satisfaction she feels as he sees him stutter and stumbles back outweighs the overwhelming feeling of numbness.

Adora hears a distant shout behind her, it molds together with the explosions that she can hear very clearly but she yields at her body shutting down, her knees buckling. She expects to fall with a thud but all she feels is warmth enveloping her. That voice pierces through her again, jostling her awake.

“...Dora!... Adora!” She looks up at the voice, hyper fixates on *her*. Always *her*. “You’ve done it, Adora. He’s gone. You did it.” Despite the distraught look on Catra and Adora’s pain seeping through her, she can’t help but think that Catra looks so beautiful in front of her. She lets out a shaky breath and cups the cheek of the beautiful mess in front of her. “It’s over, Adora, he’s gone. It’s over,” Catra repeats, almost begging.

“Catra…,” she says as she feels herself fading away. This time she can’t bring herself to fight. Her mind is fuzzy but Catra’s face is too hard to ignore. Tears are hitting her face as her companion lets out the tears she knew she was holding on to. It hurts Adora seeing her like this. Catra doesn’t deserve to be sad anymore, Adora knows just how much pain this girl has suffered. She deserves to be happy. “I want you to come home, promise me you’ll come home.” She thumbs away, the tears that fall from Catra’s eyes.

“Come home with me!” Catra’s hand covers Adora’s, her other hand cradling Adora’s head, pulling her closer like it would help, “Come home with me, idiot.”

Adora has seen her angry, she’s seen her happy, scared, she’s seen all forms of Catra but she has never seen her this broken. It breaks something in Adora that hurts more than the wounds given to her. She wants to stay. She wants to come home and hold Catra close to her arms and hug all the broken pieces they did to each other.

Together? Together!

“Cata, I’m sorry. I’m so sorry.” She smiles but her eyes feel so heavy with tears. She’s slowly losing her grip. “In another lifetime, things will be different between me and you.” There are so many words she wants to say, so many things she wants to show Catra but she can’t hold on much longer. “In another lifetime, maybe–” she looks back on everything she’s done and hasn’t done. The choices she’s made and the choices she wishes she chose. She’s almost there, she can feel it, “maybe we’d have a chance, together.”

Her heartbeat was beating louder than before. She can feel the vibrations in her own eardrums going slower and slower. She stares directly at Catra’s mismatched eyes. Her soul getting lost inside their orbs. Suddenly, she doesn’t feel as afraid anymore. To see *her*, to be this close to *her*. She feels something tugging at her, urging her to go.

“I will meet you in another lifetime and maybe then I’ll get to tell you just how much I’ve missed you and just how much–” she’s ready. She’s nearly there, “just how much, I love you.”

* * *

“Where do you think we go after we die?” The sky's turned into an ombre color of blue and pink, they look out into the horizon, waiting for the sun to peak.

“Do you have a death wish or something, Adora?” Catra looked incredulously over at Adora, whose gaze is still stuck to the skies.

It’s too early for them to be up and too early for them to be up on the roof, not that they were allowed in the first place. They can hear animals starting to move and awake from their slumber deep inside the forest. The leftovers of the night’s air still hang over their surroundings. If you really concentrate, you could almost smell the bread and pastry wafting on the air from a nearby town. It was their own little ritual and in these moments, they live in their own little world where it stops for them as they wait for the sun to rise.

“No!” Adora says, shoving Catra lightly on the shoulder, “I’m just wondering. Shadow Weaver said that God has special places for good and bad people,” she continued, now looking down with a pensive look.

“Yeah, yeah, yeah; heaven and hell or whatever,” Catra rolled her eyes from remembering the long lecture of Shadow Weaver but as she turned back to Adora, the girl still had that worried expression on her face. “What? Are you worried that you won’t go to heaven? As if they won’t accept you, you’re the perfect Princess!”

“I’ll have you know that I’m a knight,” Adora said, changing the pitch in her voice and lifting the wooden sword beside her (the one she never lets go of). She falters her stance after a second, she continued, “She always said that heaven is a place of paradise, a place where you will be eternally happy. You’ll find everything you ever wanted in heaven…”

Catra can feel a “but” somewhere there and she waited for the blonde to continue then Adora turned to her so quickly with that face of worry etched on her face that Adora usually wore when she’s inside her head, it startled Catra.

"But if I die and you're still alive, how can it be a happy place? What if all I ever wanted was you and you're the only thing that makes me happy… Would that make my heaven hell if that's the case?"

Catra stared at her in disbelief. It sometimes amazed her just how weird and wonderful her companion's mind can be. Suddenly she felt herself bubble with humor, giggling at the prospect of that mysterious mind. She stopped herself short once she saw the absolute turmoil on Adora's face.

"What are you talking about? You're not gonna die, Adora. I'll make sure of it, remember we protect each other?" she snorted and placed a comforting hand on Adora's shoulder.

"But what if!" Adora's hands became frantic, vaguely making gestures.

Catra could only sigh and scoot closer to the girl, wanting more warmth from the still cold air. "I don't really believe in what that old hag says," she commented, earning her a smack on the arm, "I mean, are you really going to believe in those superficial things?"

She can feel Adora stiffen from her words. The girl then turned away from her and looked back to the horizon where the sun was rising. "Then what else is there for us when we die?" Adora hugged her knees, still staring out into the horizon in thought. "Do we just cease to exist?"

Catra never really thought about those things and she didn't even have the privilege to. Every day is just a gamble of whether or not you live or you die. Sometimes they're lucky enough to eat two meals in a day or get to drink fresh water. She followed Adora and hugged her knees in thought, looking out into the horizon as well.

"You know," Catra started, still mindlessly staring out into the world, "Lonnie once met this weirdo kid in town, when we went out for the fair? She told me that this kid was rambling on and on

about other worlds or whatever, "different timeline" that kid said." Catra laughed recalling when Lonnie was telling her the story. "Lonnie told me that the kid said when we die we get reincarnated into a different lifetime," Catra finished, taking a glance back at Adora who was now interested in her tale.

"Re- rein-," Adora tried to say the word back but was having trouble, Catra could only giggle at the effort and how her face twisted into confusion. It made Catra's heart skip a beat every time the blonde would make that face or any face for that matter.

"Reincarnated, dummy. It's basically your soul transferring to a new body once you die to a different lifetime or whatever." Catra now fully facing Adora again sees the girl's eyebrows raise in wonder. There's that twinkle in her eyes again.

"So when you die, you start over?" Adora's voice was hopeful and her lips were trying not to twitch up. Catra can feel something in her stomach crawl, tickling her with the same familiar feeling she gets when she's with Adora.

"Yeah, something like that," Catra absentmindedly answers, too busy eyeing Adora as the blonde begins contemplating on something. "What's in that weird head of yours?"

"Would we still be together? In another lifetime I mean, would our new lives be with each other?" Adora furrows her brows, unsure.

"I mean, obviously. Together, remember?" and when she sees that Adora has yet to be convinced she continues, "And if your sorry ass dies first, then I guess I'll just have to find you."

"Really?"

"Yeah. I'll find you. Always."

Adora let out the biggest grin that Catra has ever seen her do. The blonde stands up abruptly, raising her wooden sword towards where the sun is rising. "Catra and Adora together forever! Even after death!"

Catra laughs, trying to sit her back down and hushing her, "you'll wake up the rest! They're so going to snitch on us again!" But she's still laughing as she says this, knowing that they won't, knowing that they knew that this was Catra and Adora's little moment together and that they've always done this and will always do this.

Adora laughs with her, not budging from where she stands, she turns to Catra with that big goofy smile on her face. "I'll find you too. I'll always find you."

* * *

Catra's head is buried at the crook of Adora's neck. Her smell is a mixture of all kinds of things from the sea, the smell of blood, of fire, of the sweat she wears, but mostly Catra could smell that distinct smell that Adora has, it's earthy and it's the kind of smell that reminds you of the sun rising after a dark night. It's faint now, but Catra can still smell it as she sobs on Adora, still cradling her in her arms. Blood smears all over her as she does so.

"Don't you get it?" she holds Adora's body closer, wanting to feel that heat once more but it was too cold, "I love you. I always have," she's desperately sobbing, Adora's hand went limp a while ago but she holds it close, gripping it for dear life. "Please, just this once, stay. Stay."

But she doesn't. No matter how much she wants her too, how much she wishes she would stay, she doesn't. Adora's gone.

Catra lifts herself up slightly to look at her. Her eyes are shut peacefully, the most peaceful look Catra has ever seen her. She gingerly places the hand she holds on the blonde's armored chest, lingering her fingers at the touch before moving it to fix Adora's short hair. Brushing at her blonde bangs with her fingers. Her eyes fill with tears, clouding her vision, but she can still see Adora, she

can always see Adora. She grips at the limp body she's holding, closer and tighter. She remembers all the times she wanted to hold her like this and all the times she chose not to. Something shivers inside her, a tight grip holding where her heart lies.

In another lifetime.

She smiles despite the pain. It seems stupid and futile but only Adora can give her hope like this. Even in her last final breath, she would say these things. She lowers her head and kisses Adora's forehead gently then continues to brush her hair with her hand.

"Maybe in another lifetime you'd be grinning like an idiot at how sappy I am while I hold you like this. Maybe in another lifetime I'd get to hear your stupid laugh one more time– all the time, with your stupid snort," she laughs at her words, the tightness on her chest grows, "Maybe…" She stops and grits her teeth, holding back any tears that were dreading to fall. She shakily moves her hand to cup at the deceased knight's cheek.

"Maybe in another lifetime I'd do everything right, maybe I'd get to kiss you, hold you close and tell you over and over again just how much I love you. Maybe you'd stay then. In another lifetime, we'd be together, like we always said. In another lifetime, I'd find you and we'll go home together." But not in this lifetime.

* * *

Brightmoon - After the war

"What are you doing up?" Catra turns around to find her wife standing by the entree way of their balcony. The orange streak from the sun, illuminating her blonde hair. Catra smiles at her,

beckoning her to come closer where she leans on the railings, looking out into the horizon.

“Just enjoying the sunrise,” Catra sighs as she feels Adora holds her from behind, protecting her from the cold air. Her tail wraps around her wife’s leg and holds the hands that rest on her stomach. They stay like this for a moment, feeling the newfound magic that lingers all around Etheria and enjoying the sky turning orange.

“Come here.” Adora nudges Catra, leading her to the center of their balcony, the water from their fountain giving off quiet noises as it flows down. She holds Catra’s hand with hers and places her other one on Catra’s hips. The brunette follows her lead, grasping at the hand on her and putting her other on top of Adora’s shoulder.

They sway their body, following the rhythm of the music from the environment around them. Their foreheads touching, both wearing peaceful smiles on their faces.

Adora lets go of the hand that holds Catra and moves it over under Catra’s chin, lifting it up so she could face the blonde. They stare at each other. Absorbing anything and everything they can as if they would never see each other again.

“I’m so happy,” Adora spoke after a moment, "I found you."

“You make me happy,” Catra continues, "and I found you."

“I missed you, you know.” Adora lowers her gaze, breaking away the eye contact they had and lowering her hand to hold Catra’s again, squeezing it lightly.

“I know.” Catra grips back, reassuring her. She leans in close, filling the space they left from each other. Their lips meet, soft and tender, like the feelings they feel right now. They break away, staring at each other again, feeling their hot breath from each other. “I love you.”

“I love you too,” Adora says back, kissing her again, “and I’ll keep loving you. In this lifetime and the next lifetime and the lifetime after that. Always.” She kisses her again then gazes back into those mismatched eyes. “Together?”

“Together.” And they dance until the sun is fully up, lighting everything in Etheria. They dance and welcome a new day, together.

End Notes

I really enjoyed brainstorming with this Au. I kinda want to make a separate multichapter fic of this but I'm not sure yet. Tell me what you think in the comments! Constructive criticism is very much welcome here and I'd like to hear what you think!

I'd like to thank my friend who kept screaming at me to finish and also helped me with proofreading the first few parts of the story :D

I also have a Catradora playlist that was also a big inspiration for this fic: https://open.spotify.com/playlist/5mciSodOZPLfZaMmc4i1Tx?si=oRQPDMNKQR2lg9yaqLZTWw

I hope you have a good day/night/afternoon!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!